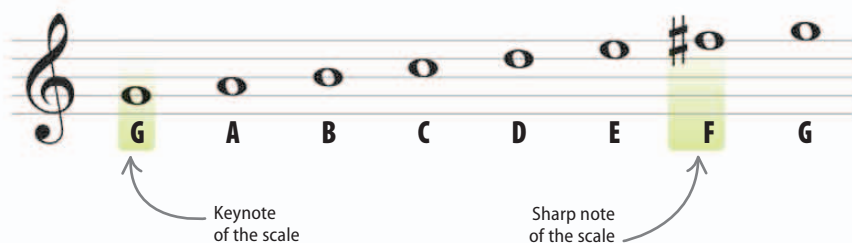


Keys

A key is the harmonic, or tonal, center of a piece of music. Keys determine which notes should usually be played as sharps or flats.

What is a key?

A piece in a particular key is based around the notes of that key's corresponding scale. The first note of a scale is known as the keynote, or tonic. For example, in a G major scale, the keynote is G. Music in the key of G major is mainly made up of the notes from a G major scale, so F will usually be sharp.



△ Key notes

With music in the key of G major, the keynote is G, and the note F will usually be played as F#.

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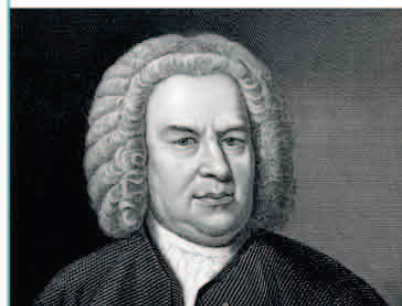
SEE ALSO

◀ 60–61	Major scales
◀ 62–63	Minor scales
The relative minor	68–69 ▶
The circle of fifths	70–71 ▶
Harmony	118–119 ▶

REAL WORLD

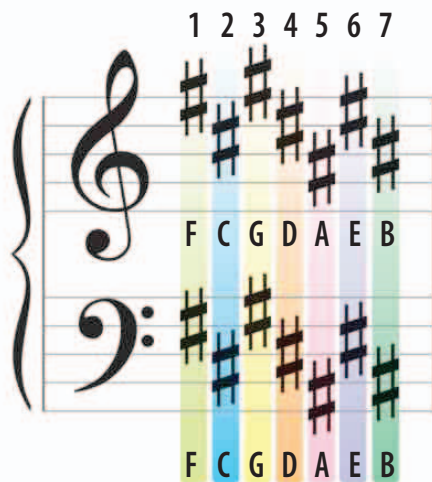
Johann Sebastian Bach

Composers write music in all kinds of different keys, even ones that need lots of sharps and flats. J. S. Bach's *The Well-Tempered Clavier* is a collection of pieces in all 24 of the major and minor keys.



What is a key signature?

A piece of music in a particular key will tend to use the same sharps or flats many times. Rather than writing the sharps or flats into the music every time they occur, they can be written at the beginning of the staff as a key signature. Key signatures indicate that notes should always be played as sharps or flats unless they are canceled by naturals.



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◁ Sharps in a key signature

The sharps in a key signature are always written in this order: F# first, then C#, followed by G#, D#, A#, E#, and finally B#.



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◁ Flats in a key signature

The flats in a key signature are always written in the reverse order from the sharps: Bb first, then Eb, followed by Ab, Db, Gb, Cb, and finally Fb.